

ON PARADE, THE PRAETORIAN GUARD WORE DECORATED ARMOR. AT OTHER TIMES, THEY WORE PLAIN ARMOR.



the Praetorian Guard. It was a force of up to 10,000 carefully chosen men whose duty was to protect the emperor from injury and rebellions. The Praetorians lived in their own barracks on the outskirts of Rome. Emperors after Augustus continued to use the Praetorians as their personal bodyguards, but as time passed, the political power of these elite soldiers grew. If they

disliked an emperor, they might murder him and replace him with a leader they preferred.

### **A risky job**

It was the custom for Roman soldiers to cheer a victorious general, calling out "*Imperator!*", meaning "our commander" or "our emperor." An ambitious general might take this as a sign that the army wanted